

Digital Passion | Tomorrow

Next is to understand how people use computers, both at home and at work. If you have a Net connection, you will find that, today, the most important software on your system is your browser. Regardless of whether it's IE, Firefox or Opera, which is your personal choice, Orkut, Gmail, Google, Windows Live, Yahoo!, Facebook, MySpace, YouTube, et al, are all online, and you want to get at them. With push-mail, your work e-mail is location independent, and spreadsheets and presentations are accessible in Google Docs. So what is it that you really *have* to use *your PC* for?

Gaming

Ah! Here we come to the first and biggest hurdle in why the future of desktop OSes is not bleak. With the majority of PC games being built for Microsoft's DirectX, it's not hard to see a Microsoft OS continuing to dominate. However, consoles have also started selling like never before, as people fed up with constant hardware upgrades have opted for a gaming experience on the PS3, Xbox or Wii. With more of us getting hooked on to games, it stands to reason that the OS we use will have to play the games we like.

Anywhere Computing

Ambitious projects like the Alky Project (fallingleafsystems.com), which wanted to make it possible for DirectX games to run on Linux and Mac, may have failed, but the effort was made in the right direction. They've even made their code open source, for people who want to continue where they left off. After all, games developers would like nothing more than to have their games open up to Linux and Mac users.

However, set aside thoughts of gaming, and focus on everything else, and it's really not that hard to imagine an Internet OS, or even multiple OSes that do only what they're supposed to—act as an interface between hardware and software. Today, it's not just Windows that tries to be a one-stop solution for all your needs, as Linux distros and Apple are also trying to do exactly that. I'm not so sure that OSes should try and offer all of that to us. For example, I'm tired of the ever-bloating sizes of OSes—Windows 95 shipped on floppies, and now Vista ships on a DVD! Windows XP is my personal favourite, because it seemed to offer not just the right amount of security, but also a good experience on mid-range hardware.

A refreshing new concept is SplashTop, which is a Linux distribution that motherboard manufacturers are installing to an inbuilt flash-chip on motherboards. What this means for us users is that you can have ultra-low powered systems that require no hard drives to check mail or surf. ASUS, for example uses SplashTop on motherboards that they brand as

“Express Gate”. OSes like SplashTop do away with worrying about hardware requirements, and instead of trying to be one-stop-solutions, just let you connect to the Net and get your work done. It's also useful for notorious fiddlers like me, because now I can troubleshoot problems in my primary OS installation and download fixes for whatever I screwed up in Vista while fiddling with settings.

FutureOS

Anyway, coming back to my quest, I need to list what I would want from my “FutureOS”, so here's my wish-list:

Light and fast: Instead of taking ages to boot, and hogging memory for services, I'd rather have an OS that uses the same amount of (or less than) resources as Windows XP.

Interfaces: Like I mentioned, touch is a given, but I would love to have thought computing capability. Not much the OS developers can do to give us this though, but let's hope research in this field is successful.

Portability: This is something that's really important, because I'd rather carry a pen drive with me instead of a laptop, and I also would want to have a familiar interface on all my devices.

Server-side: GoogleOS (GooOS?) or Midori, if they're actually released would solve a lot of problems for all of us. I'd love to have the same Desktop, Documents, Favorites, and more, on every device I use. This way I could log on, check my mail, surf and then download stuff to some virtual drive somewhere, just once, and be able to access it from anywhere.

Application rentals: I use Adobe Photoshop for about 2 hours a month when I need to edit some images. Rather than have me wait to use a designer's computer, my company bought me a license. It's the same for many of us, with a long list of applications. Let's consider a Net-enabled OS from, say, Google. Just as you have advertisements in Gmail, I'd settle for advertisements in GoogleOS, or a small subscription fee, to allow me to use software such as Photoshop for a few hours a week or month. Plus, it would mean not having to install / uninstall applications, or have my system slow down because I have too many things installed.

Remember, this is just what I could come up with based on my usage patterns—a lot of you will have many more ideas for what FutureOS should consist of. Make sure to write in and tell us some of those ideas, and maybe together we can convince developers to start working in this direction. Some of you might even be developers yourselves, who can, or may already have formed groups to develop software that will allow us to experience OS-utopia. You too should write in and inform us of your efforts. ☑

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